ALTERNATIVE APPROACH · PAYMENTS MODERNIZATION

The 2027 Payout Simplification

A simpler road to the same destination: hold guest payments on NAT's own platform, then pay every tour operator their share on a schedule you control — using the payout system we already run today.

PROJECT PROPOSAL · ALTERNATIVE PATH

Prepared for
NAT Leadership

Prepared by
Product & Engineering

Date
September 2026

Applies to
Tours departing 2027 onward

Companion to
The 2027 Operator Transfer Upgrade

Status
For review — nothing built yet

EXECUTIVE OVERVIEW

The same goal, a simpler road there

Everything we set out to achieve with the original Transfer Upgrade still holds. What's changed is how we actually get there — and it's meaningfully lighter to build.

The original plan was straightforward: for any tour **departing 2027 or later**, the guest's payment lands with NAT first, and NAT explicitly sends each operator their share as its own step — unlocking a single checkout across multiple operators, with full visibility into every payment along the way.

One of our own leads raised a good question since then: does that operator payment need to move the *instant* a guest pays, or could it move on a predictable schedule instead — the same way NAT already pays operators today? Once we looked closely, the answer is yes. NAT already runs a working payout system that sends operators their money on a schedule — daily, weekly, or monthly. This alternative simply lets that same, already-trusted system carry the 2027 booking funds too, instead of building an entirely new instant-transfer engine to sit alongside it.

The result is the same destination — one guest payment, split cleanly across every operator involved, fully visible to our team — reached with a noticeably smaller amount of new, untested code.



One Checkout, Many Operators — Still True

A single guest payment still splits across every operator in a combo cart. That capability doesn't change; only its timing does.



Reuses What Already Works

The same payout system already sending operators their money today simply carries one more kind of funds through it.



Far Less New Machinery

No new instant, per-booking transfer step to build — and no matching per-booking reversal step needed for every refund.



Same Safe, Reversible Rollout

The same on/off control, and the same guarantee that every 2026-and-earlier booking is untouched, forever.

> *"The vision hasn't changed — one guest payment, many operators, full visibility. What's simpler is how NAT actually gets each operator their money."*

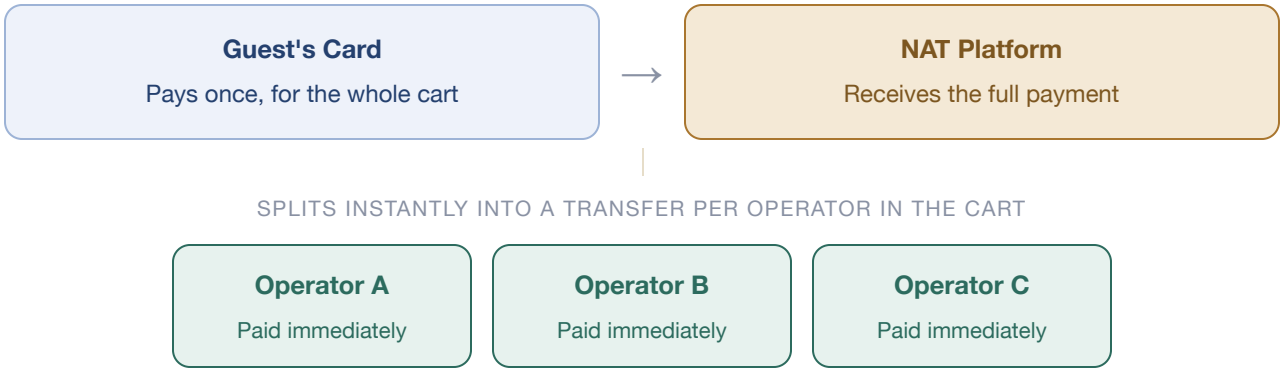
HOW IT WORKS

Two ways to reach the same place

Both paths start identically. They differ only in when each operator actually receives their share.

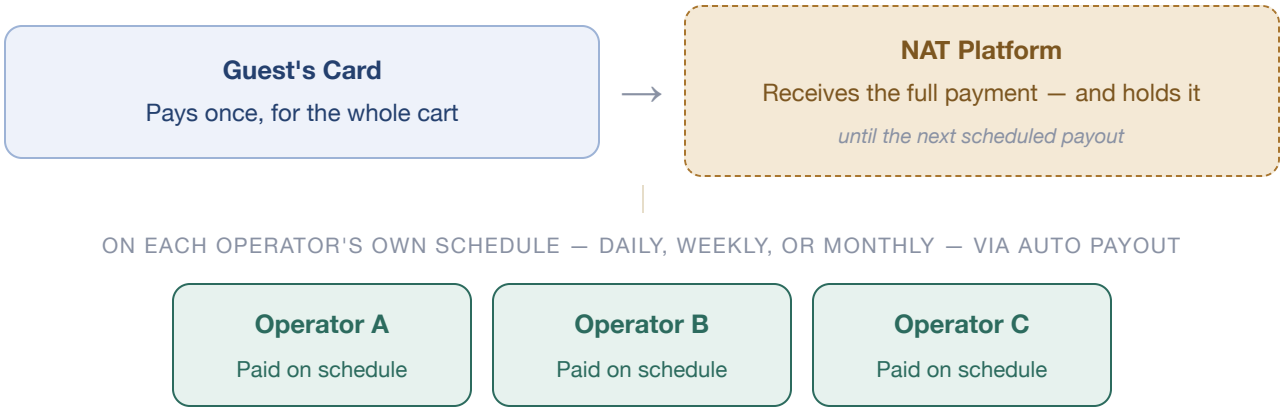
As a reminder, right now every payment is split automatically the instant a guest pays — but only ever to **one** operator's account (see *The 2027 Operator Transfer Upgrade* for the full detail on today's limit). Both paths below solve that same limit. The difference between them is entirely about timing.

ORIGINAL PLAN · INSTANT, THE MOMENT A GUEST PAYS



Requires a brand-new instant transfer step — and a matching reversal step for every refund and cancellation, since money has already moved by the time a guest asks for money back.

THIS ALTERNATIVE · HELD, THEN PAID ON A SCHEDULE



Uses NAT's existing Auto Payout system — the same one already moving money to operators today — extended to also carry 2027+ booking funds. A refund issued before that operator's payout runs is simply a plain refund; nothing has moved yet, so there's nothing to reverse.

Why now?

As of today, **no tour dated 2027 or later has been booked or sold anywhere on the platform yet.** That gives us the same risk-free window the original plan identified: we can build and thoroughly test this quietly, with zero chance of disrupting a real guest or booking. The deadline that matters is having this in place before the first 2027 tour date is opened for sale — which most operators do around **October 2026**, not January 1, 2027 itself.

SET EXPECTATIONS

What stays the same, and the one thing that doesn't

This alternative is just as narrow in scope as the original plan — with one honest, clearly-flagged difference for operators.

Unchanged, guaranteed

- Guests check out exactly the same way, on web, mobile, and in person.
- Every booking for a tour dated 2026 or earlier is completely unaffected, forever.
- Pricing, fees, and commission splits are calculated exactly as they are today.
- A single guest payment still splits cleanly across every operator in a combo cart.

Built on proven technology — twice over

Like the original plan, this reuses the payment-splitting pattern NAT already relies on for partner-commission bookings. It goes one step further: it also reuses **Auto Payout**, the system already sending operators their money on a real schedule today. Two systems already proven in production, combined, rather than one brand-new engine built from scratch.

Scope, in one sentence

This alternative covers **card and card-reader payments only**, for tours departing in **2027 or later**. It does not touch cash, check, or other offline payment records, and it does not touch the separate system that already pays tour guides their own gratuities.

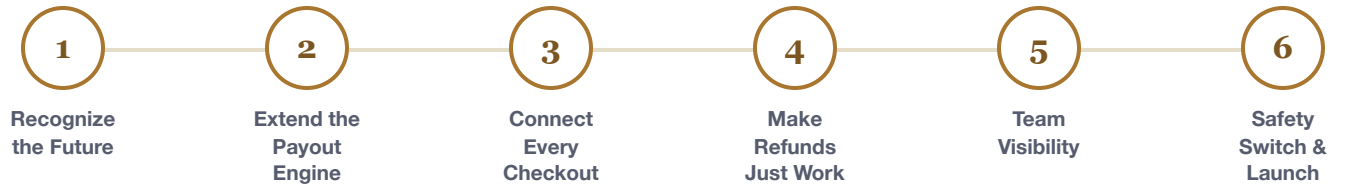
The one thing that does change for operators

Today — and under the original plan — an operator's share lands in their account the instant a guest pays. Under this alternative, for 2027+ bookings, it lands on whatever schedule they're set up for: daily, weekly, or monthly. That's the one real difference operators will notice, and it should be presented to them plainly, as a clear choice, alongside the schedule options — not as a silent change to how quickly they're paid.

THE PLAN

The same six milestones — two of them lighter

This alternative doesn't reorganize the original roadmap. It keeps every milestone, and simply makes two of them substantially smaller to build.



1 **Recognize the Future** UNCHANGED

Teach the system to spot a 2027+ booking the instant it's paid for, and permanently record which payment method applies to it. Identical to the original plan — and much of it is already built.

2 **Extend the Payout Engine We Already Have** LIGHTER

Teach Auto Payout — the system already sending operators their money today — to also carry each operator's ticket-cost share out of NAT's balance, on the same schedule it already uses. Smaller than building a brand-new instant-transfer engine.

3 **Connect Every Way Guests Can Pay** UNCHANGED

Roll the new charge routing out across every checkout flow — web, mobile, admin, and in-person card readers — one at a time, each fully tested. Identical to the original plan.

4 **Make Refunds Just Work** LIGHTER

Before an operator's payout has run, a refund is simply a plain refund — there's nothing to reverse. We only need new handling for the rare case where a refund lands after that operator's share has already gone out.

5 **Give Our Team Visibility** LIGHTER

Surface anything that didn't go through cleanly. Auto Payout already keeps its own run history and approval log today, so a meaningful part of this may already exist and just need extending.

6 **A Safety Switch, and a Careful Launch** UNCHANGED

The same controllable on/off switch, the same rehearsal in a safe test environment, the same instant way back if anything looks wrong.

CONTINUITY

What happens to the work already under way

Nothing here is wasted. Most of it carries over directly.

Engineering has already made real progress against the original plan — most notably Milestone 1 (teaching the system to recognize a 2027+ booking) and a meaningful share of Milestone 3 (connecting the checkout flows). None of that changes under this alternative: it's the same foundation, reused exactly as built.

What this alternative retires is narrower than it might sound: specifically, the *instant, per-booking* transfer step from Milestone 2, and its matching per-booking reversal step from Milestone 4. That work wasn't wasted effort, either — it's precisely what let us discover this simpler alternative exists and confirm it's sound, and the pattern it proved out (a payment landing fully on NAT's balance, with a separate, explicit step paying the operator) is exactly what this alternative still relies on. The only change is that the "separate, explicit step" now runs on Auto Payout's schedule instead of firing the instant a guest pays.

NET EFFECT

Less new code to write, fewer new edge cases to test for every refund and cancellation path, and a smaller, more isolated piece of engineering — while keeping every guarantee the original plan made.

WORTH DECIDING TOGETHER

A few honest questions before we commit

This alternative is sound and meaningfully simpler to build — but holding guest funds for longer than an instant does raise a few real questions worth deciding on purpose, not by default.

How long should NAT hold a guest's payment before an operator sees their share?

Daily, weekly, and monthly payouts each mean a different length of time NAT is holding an operator's money. Worth agreeing on the default, and whether every operator gets the same choice.

Who's responsible if a guest disputes a charge?

Because the full payment sits on NAT's own account rather than splitting immediately, a dispute lands with NAT first. If an operator's share has already been paid out, recovering it becomes something NAT follows up on directly, rather than something handled automatically. Worth a quick look from whoever handles compliance and finance.

What happens if a refund lands after an operator's already been paid?

The clean answer: net it against that operator's next scheduled payout, the same way Auto Payout already recalculates what's owed each cycle. Worth confirming this is how we want it explained to operators, too.

Which payout schedules do we actually want to offer?

Daily, weekly, monthly, or some mix — worth deciding upfront, since it's the one change we're asking operators to notice.

SIDE BY SIDE

Original plan versus this alternative

Same starting point, same guarantees. The difference is concentrated in two rows.

DIMENSION	TODAY (EVERY BOOKING)	ORIGINAL PLAN	THIS ALTERNATIVE
When an operator is paid	Instantly, automatically	Instantly, via a new transfer step	**On their schedule — daily, weekly, or monthly**
Many operators, one checkout	Not possible today	Yes	Yes — unchanged
What a refund has to do	Nothing extra — handled automatically	Reverse the operator's transfer, then refund the guest	**Nothing extra, unless the operator's already been paid for that booking**
New engineering required	—	A full instant-transfer engine, plus matching reversal logic everywhere refunds happen	**One extension to Auto Payout, plus a small clawback step for late refunds**
Applies to	Every booking	2027+ bookings, if approved	2027+ bookings, if approved — 2026 and earlier unaffected either way

Both the original plan and this alternative are still proposals today — nothing described in either has been built or turned on for any live booking.

MOVING FORWARD

Recommended next steps

This is presented as an alternative, not a replacement decided in advance — we'd like your read on it before we commit engineering time either way.

Let's decide together

Once you've had a chance to weigh this alongside the original Transfer Upgrade plan, we're ready to proceed with whichever path — or combination — makes the most sense for NAT.

1. Review this alongside *The 2027 Operator Transfer Upgrade* and share your read.
2. Confirm the open questions on the previous page — particularly payout timing and dispute handling.
3. Tell us which path to build, and we begin with Milestone 1 — already largely proven either way.

How we'll keep you posted

After each milestone is complete and tested, you'll get a short, plain-language update — what's now working, and what's next. No lengthy status meetings required unless you'd like them.

We're looking forward to building this with you.

Devat Karetha
Solutions Lead